ARTICLE · ASSURANCE

What Sustainability Assurance Actually Looks Like

Demystifying ISAE 3000 and ISAE 3410 for the teams about to go through their first engagement.

Written by Ifat Sarfraz, ACMA, APFA · Last updated 11 September 2026

Get this article as a PDF

The full readiness checklist and evidence-gap list, formatted as one file to share with your team.

DOWNLOAD PDF

Most companies preparing their first sustainability report focus enormous energy on the disclosure itself — getting the materiality assessment right, choosing between GRI and IFRS S1/S2, writing the narrative. Then assurance shows up almost as an afterthought: a line item, a signature, a stamp of credibility.

That is a mistake. Assurance is where the report meets scrutiny for the first time. And for most companies going through it for the first time, the experience is confusing — not because the standards are unreasonable, but because nobody explained what the auditor is actually doing, or why.

This piece is for the finance and sustainability teams about to go through their first engagement, or the ones who went through one and were caught off guard.

TWO STANDARDS, TWO JOBS

The difference is worth understanding before an engagement begins

Sustainability assurance work is generally carried out under one of two standards.

GENERAL STANDARD

ISAE 3000 (Revised)

The general standard for assurance engagements on subject matter other than historical financial

NARROWER SCOPE

ISAE 3410

Applies specifically to assurance on greenhouse gas statements — when a company's GHG inventory is information. It is the standard most sustainability assurance is performed under — covering GHG emissions, social metrics, governance disclosures, and the full range of ESG content.

assured as a standalone statement, or as the GHG-specific component of a broader engagement.

In practice, many engagements draw on both: ISAE 3000 for the sustainability report as a whole, and ISAE 3410 for the emissions data within it, since GHG quantification carries its own methodological issues — boundary setting, emission factors, Scope 3 estimation — that the general standard does not address in as much depth.

THE DISTINCTION THAT CHANGES EVERYTHING

Limited assurance vs. reasonable assurance

This is the single most consequential decision in the engagement, and the one most companies do not understand going in.

Limited assurance is what almost every company starts with. The auditor performs inquiry and analytical procedures — asking questions, reviewing documentation, checking for plausibility — and concludes that nothing has come to their attention suggesting the information is materially misstated. It is a negative-form conclusion: lower cost, lower audit intensity, but also a lower bar of credibility.

Reasonable assurance is the higher bar, comparable in rigor to a financial statement audit. The auditor performs substantive testing, gathers sufficient appropriate evidence, and gives a positive-form conclusion — that the information is fairly presented, in all material respects. This is what CSRD ultimately requires companies to move toward over time, and what sophisticated stakeholders increasingly expect for GHG data specifically.

Companies frequently underestimate how much more evidence reasonable assurance demands. Moving from limited to reasonable is not a matter of degree — it changes what the auditor tests, how much, and what documentation they need to see.

UNDER THE HOOD

What auditors are actually checking

Strip away the standard's language and an assurance engagement is checking four things.

1 **Completeness**

Has everything material been captured? For emissions, this means checking that no significant source, facility, or activity has been left out of the boundary. For broader ESG metrics, it means checking that the reporting boundary matches what was disclosed as the scope.

2 **Accuracy**

Do the numbers reconcile? Can a disclosed figure be traced back to source data — meter readings, invoices, HR records, supplier data — without unexplained adjustments along the way?

3 **Methodology consistency**

Was the same calculation approach applied consistently across the reporting period and across comparable prior periods? A change in emission factor, consolidation approach, or estimation method needs to be identified and justified, not buried.

4 **Governance over the process**

Is there an actual internal process producing this data, with defined ownership, review, and controls — or is the report being assembled once a year by one person under deadline pressure? A report with no underlying process cannot be relied on to repeat correctly next year.

COMMON FINDINGS

Where companies get caught out

A few evidence gaps come up again and again, and they are almost always preventable.

No data trail from source to disclosure

A figure appears in the report, but nobody can show the auditor the underlying utility bill, production log, or system export it came from. This is the single most common finding — and the most avoidable, if data is retained and organized as it is generated rather than reconstructed at reporting time.

Undocumented estimates

Scope 3 data especially relies on estimates, proxies, and secondary data. That is expected — but the methodology behind the estimate needs to be documented and defensible, not just a number that appears with no explanation of how it was derived.

Boundary inconsistency

The entities included in the sustainability report do not match the entities included in the financial consolidation, and nobody can explain why. This raises immediate questions about completeness.

No management sign-off trail

Auditors expect evidence that someone with authority reviewed and approved the data before it went into the report — not just that the report was produced.

Prior-year figures that don't tie out

Comparative figures are restated without disclosure of why, often because the underlying calculation methodology quietly changed.

PREPARATION

How to actually prepare

Preparation for assurance should start well before the reporting deadline, not after the draft report is finished. A few things make the biggest difference.

Build a data trail as you go. Retain source documents — invoices, meter readings, HR exports, supplier responses — organized by disclosure item, not scattered across departments to be hunted down later.

Document your methodology once, properly. A short internal memo describing calculation approach, emission factors used, and estimation methods for each metric saves enormous time during fieldwork.

Assign clear ownership. Every disclosed figure should have an identifiable owner who can answer questions about where it came from.

Do a readiness check before the engagement starts. A pre-assurance review — even an informal one — surfaces the gaps above while there is still time to fix them.

Treat it as a process, not an event. Companies that pass smoothly are usually the ones where sustainability data collection runs continuously through the year, not the ones assembling everything from scratch in the final weeks.

> A report that hasn't been through rigorous assurance is a claim. A report that has is evidence.

THE BIGGER POINT

Assurance is the mechanism, not the formality

Assurance is not a formality bolted onto the end of a reporting cycle — it is the mechanism that determines whether a sustainability report can actually be trusted by the people reading it: lenders, investors, buyers running supply chain due diligence, and regulators. A report that hasn't been through rigorous assurance is a claim. A report that has is evidence.

For companies exporting into markets where buyers and regulators are asking harder questions every year, that distinction is only going to matter more.

FREE DOWNLOADABLE RESOURCE

Take this article with you

What Sustainability Assurance Actually Looks Like — PDF

The full article as a print-ready PDF: evidence gaps, the readiness checklist, and what auditors test for under ISAE 3000/3410.

DOWNLOAD PDF

Written by **Ifat Sarfraz, ACMA, APFA** · Sustainability Reporting & Assurance (ISAE 3000/3410) · GreenMetrics

GreenMetrics

GreenMetrics is Ifat Sarfraz's sustainability reporting and assurance practice. This article is a readiness aid, not legal or regulatory advice. Confirm current standards before making binding commercial decisions.